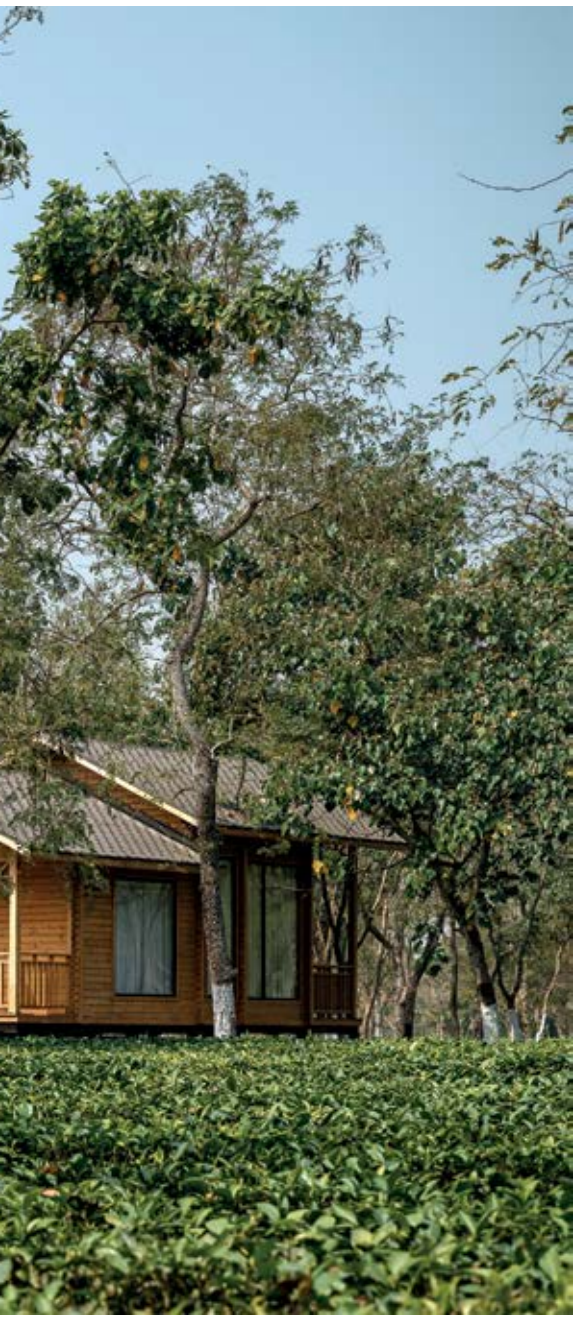




The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate in Assam (Left); Here, the rugged range comes right up to the glass: Lie back on a daybed in the warmth of a Ladakhi bukhari (Above)

These are not indulgent add-ons; they are forms of friction removal that return control of time to the traveller.

Food is equally important. A buffet may be efficient, but efficiency can flatten geography. If breakfast looks identical in Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Goa, Gir and Karnataka, the hotel has removed one of the most immediate ways of understanding where one has woken up. Regional menus, organic vegetable gardens on-site, local produce and a genuine farm-to-table philosophy make dining part of interpreting the destination rather than a neutral service function.

India is particularly suited to that proposition. Its hospitality opportunity is not confined to destinations the world already knows. The next great luxury circuit may run through coffee estates in Chikmagalur, tea country in Assam, tiger landscapes in Central India, the cold desert of Ladakh, overlooked stretches of coastline, river valleys, destinations rooted in Ayurveda and wellness, and even major pilgrimage destinations such as Tirupati. Such destinations need hospitality capable of making them accessible without diluting what made them worth discovering in the first place.

The opportunity, then, is not simply to build more hotels in India's established destinations. It is to use hospitality to give travellers compelling reasons to discover places that have so far sat outside the conventional luxury circuit. The next generation of boutique hotels has the potential not simply to populate India's tourism map, but to redraw it.